

Huge Egyptian Museum Opens for Test Run

The Grand Egyptian Museum in Giza will open a limited number of exhibits about ancient Egypt starting this week. The limited opening will be a test run of the still-unannounced official opening of the museum, officials said.

Starting on October 16, 4,000 visitors per day will be permitted to view limited areas of the main galleries, said Al-Tayeb Abbas. He is assistant to Egypt's minister of antiquities.

Museum officials have repeatedly delayed the museum opening for many reasons, including the COVID-19 pandemic. Some areas have been open since 2022 for limited tours.

The museum is a huge project near the famous Giza Pyramids. The building project began more than 12 years ago and has cost more than \$1 billion so far.

The Egyptian government says more than 100,000 artifacts of Egypt's ancient treasures are on show at the site. Officials describe it as the world's largest archaeological museum.

Visitors walk past ancient Egyptian statues along the Grand Staircase at the Grand Egyptian Museum in Giza, Egypt, Tuesday, Oct.15, 2024. (AP Photo/Khaled Elfiqi)

The exhibits in the test run include 12 areas that explore issues related to society, religion, and philosophies of ancient Egypt, Abbas added. The areas are divided by dynasty and historical order.

Historical divisions include the Third Intermediate Period, Late Period, and Graeco-Roman Period. It also includes the New Kingdom, Middle Kingdom, and Old Kingdom periods. They all represent life thousands of years in the past.

One of the areas displays statues of the "Elite of the King." These represent members of a king's family, and high-level officials who worked in the army, government or religious service.

Abbas told the AP that the test run would help prepare for the full opening by identifying operational issues. This includes finding out which parts of the museum might become overcrowded.

A reporter for the Associated Press spoke with some tourists at the museum.

Canadian visitor Aude Porcedda told the AP she was amazed by the museum. She said she believes it is important that the world know about Egyptian civilization.

Jorge Licano, a visitor from Costa Rica expressed similar praise.

“There is a lot of history and a lot of things we are not aware of, especially coming from the other side of the world, and seeing everything here and learning from the locals has been great,” he said.

Visitors walk past ancient Egyptian colossal statues along the Grand Staircase at the Grand Egyptian Museum in Giza, Egypt, Tuesday, Oct.15, 2024. (AP Photo/Khaled Elfiqi)

The limited opening includes the museum’s so-called Grand Staircase. It is six stories high with a view of the nearby pyramids. Also open to the public, are artifacts that include sarcophagi and statues. Other parts of the museum, including the King Tutankhamun treasure collection, are set to open at later dates.

All the exhibit space is equipped with high-level technology and permit different kinds of media presentations to help explain the lives of ancient Egyptians, including kings, said museum official, Eissa Zidan.

Some exhibits will use virtual reality to explain the history of burial and its development throughout ancient Egypt.

“The museum is not only a place to display antiquities, but it also aims to attract children to learn about ancient Egyptian history ... The museum is a gift to all the world,” Zidan told the AP.

I’m Anna Matteo.

Ahmed Hatem and Fatma Khaled reported this story for The Associated Press. Anna Matteo adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

grand - adj. ใหญ่โต, สง่างาม, โอ่อ่า

exhibit - n. นิทรรศการ, สิ่งนำมาแสดง

gallery - n. ห้องแสดงภาพ/ผลงานศิลปะ, หอศิลป์

antiquity - n. โบราณวัตถุ, วัตถุโบราณ

tour - n. การเดินทางท่องเที่ยว, การทัศนอาจร

artifact - n. สิ่งประดิษฐ์ (ของมนุษย์), โบราณวัตถุ (ที่มนุษย์สร้าง)

dynasty - n. ราชวงศ์, ตระกูลผู้ปกครอง

amazed - adj. ประหลาดใจมาก, ที่ง

sarcophagus - n. โลงศพหิน

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is the primary purpose of the Grand Egyptian Museum's limited opening this week?

- A) To officially announce the museum's grand opening.
- B) To conduct a trial or test run for the museum.
- C) To display all its ancient Egyptian artifacts to the public.
- D) To attract a large number of international tourists immediately.

2. According to Al-Tayeb Abbas, how many visitors will be allowed daily during the limited opening, and from what date?

- A) 1,000 visitors starting on October 15.
- B) 4,000 visitors starting on October 16.
- C) An unlimited number of visitors starting next week.
- D) 2,000 visitors starting from the official opening.

3. What is one significant reason mentioned for the repeated delays in the museum's opening?

- A) Lack of funding for the project.
- B) Insufficient number of artifacts.
- C) The global COVID-19 pandemic.
- D) Problems with the museum's architectural design.

4. What is the approximate total cost of the Grand Egyptian Museum project to date?

- A) Less than \$1 billion.
- B) Exactly \$1 billion.
- C) More than \$1 billion.
- D) Around \$500 million.

5. How does the Egyptian government describe the Grand Egyptian Museum in terms of its size and collection?

- A) As a small regional museum with over 50,000 artifacts.
- B) As the world's largest archaeological museum, displaying over 100,000 artifacts.
- C) As a cultural center primarily for local Egyptians.
- D) As a museum dedicated exclusively to King Tutankhamun's treasures.

6. How are the 12 exhibit areas in the test run primarily organized?

- A) By the size of the artifacts displayed.
- B) By the type of material used in the artifacts.
- C) By dynasty and historical order.

D) By geographical region within ancient Egypt.

7. Which of the following is NOT listed as a historical division featured in the museum?

- A) The Third Intermediate Period.
- B) The Early Dynastic Period.
- C) The Graeco-Roman Period.
- D) The New Kingdom.

8. What do the statues in the 'Elite of the King' exhibit represent?

- A) Everyday citizens of ancient Egypt.
- B) Only the pharaohs and queens.
- C) Members of the royal family and high-ranking officials.
- D) Foreign dignitaries who visited Egypt.

9. According to Abbas, what is a key benefit of conducting the test run before the full opening?

- A) To generate early revenue for the museum.
- B) To train new museum staff members.
- C) To identify and address operational problems.
- D) To gauge public interest in ancient Egyptian history.

10. How did Canadian visitor Aude Porcedda react to the museum?

- A) She found it somewhat underwhelming.
- B) She was amazed by it and emphasized the importance of global awareness of Egyptian civilization.
- C) She was concerned about the crowded conditions.
- D) She suggested that the museum should focus more on modern Egyptian history.

11. What did Jorge Licano, a visitor from Costa Rica, appreciate most about his visit?

- A) The modern architecture of the museum.
- B) The opportunity to learn about a vast amount of unfamiliar history and local culture.
- C) The interactive virtual reality exhibits.
- D) The proximity of the museum to the Giza Pyramids.

12. Which of the following is NOT accessible to the public during the current limited opening?

- A) The Grand Staircase.
- B) Statues and sarcophagi.

- C) The King Tutankhamun treasure collection.
- D) Areas with a view of the pyramids.

13. According to Eissa Zidan, how does the museum utilize technology in its exhibit spaces?

- A) To control the museum's climate and lighting.
- B) To monitor visitor flow and security.
- C) To provide media presentations that explain ancient Egyptian lives.
- D) To offer online virtual tours to people worldwide.

14. What specific aspect of ancient Egyptian history will some exhibits use virtual reality to explain?

- A) The construction techniques of the pyramids.
- B) The daily life of ordinary Egyptians.
- C) The history and development of burial practices.
- D) The trade routes and economic activities.

15. Besides displaying antiquities, what other aim does the museum official, Zidan, highlight?

- A) To serve as a research center for archaeologists.
- B) To attract children and encourage them to learn about ancient Egyptian history.
- C) To promote modern Egyptian art and culture.
- D) To host international conferences and events.